C2 Reading

How certain is the writer?

Read the strength of a claim in academic and news texts, from tentative suggestion to firm conclusion.

At C2, reading accurately means noticing how strongly a claim is made. *The data prove* and *the data may suggest* say very different things, and exam questions often turn on that difference.

Strength	Language
Certain	*demonstrates, proves, it is clear that, undoubtedly*
Probable	*strongly suggests, is likely to, in all probability*
Possible	*may, might, could, it is possible that, appears to*
Tentative	*there is some evidence that, it has been tentatively proposed*
Limiting the claim	*in some cases, to a certain extent, at least in the short term*

Text

A new study of 200 office workers suggests that a short walk after lunch may improve afternoon concentration. Participants who walked for ten minutes scored, on average, slightly higher on attention tests. The authors are careful to note that the effect appears modest and that the sample was drawn from a single company. Even so, some newspapers reported that walking "boosts brain power", a claim the study does not support.

Read the verb, not the topic. *Suggests*, *may* and *appears* tell you more about the writer's position than the subject of the sentence does.

Common mistake. Choosing a strong answer option such as "The study proves that walking improves concentration" when the text only says it *may*. Match the strength of the claim, not just the content.

Practice

1. How certain are the researchers that walking improves concentration?
2. Which two words show this?
3. What two limitations do the authors mention?
4. What is the writer's attitude to the newspaper headlines?
5. Which statement matches the text? (a) Walking after lunch boosts brain power. (b) There is some evidence that a short walk may slightly improve concentration. (c) Walking has no effect on concentration.

Teacher page: answers

Print the pages before this one for students.

Answers

1. Not very certain: they present it as a possible, modest effect.
2. *suggests* and *may* (also *appears*)
3. The effect is modest, and the sample came from a single company.
4. Critical: the headlines claim more than the study supports.
5. (b)